

The sadhu with the cellphone. The homeless next to a luxury apartment. The low-end call centre with the life-saving medical miracle. For the past 60 years, India has never been just a series of static images but a country in the midst of constant change.

■ By Kaveri Banzai

Life changes fast. Life changes in the instant. You sit down to dinner and life as you know it ends." Joan Didion wrote this about her writer-husband John Gregory Dunne upon his death. But the suddenness of the moment may well apply to some of the revolutions, big and small, that have swept across India. From an idea espoused by a lawyer fighting injustice in South Africa to a prime minister looking for an answer to an impoverished foreign exchange reserve. From a frail Bhadrakal raising the cry of injustice among West Bengal's peasantry to a politician looking for a wily way out of a fractious government. Transformations in India have had many auteurs and many avatars. They have flattened the world, connected people, created roads where there were dirt tracks. India's transformations, some etched in time and others continuing, have remade society, altered perceptions, and internalised change.

From the time Nicolas Copernicus figured that the earth went round the sun, revolutions have required a leap of faith and a stretch of the imagination that asks us to unlearn everything that has gone before. The world becomes a palimpsest, with the revolutionary writing his own history. Some revolutions fade, their fireworks a distant thunder, and their grandeur a fading memory. Other revolutions are renewed daily, their power infusing a million new mutinies. From the successes to the faultlines, revolutions redefine the core of the nation. It could be a tiny district learning to become 100 per cent literate, a 13-year-old distributing pamphlets against the British government, or an electronic voting machine that eliminates error. The possibilities of anger are as many as the opportunities to broadcast them. Each revolution has its unintended consequence. Through history, it could be the Code Napoleon, which was born of the French Revolution, or the feminist movement that resulted from the bicycle. It could even be the denuded Indian riches that inspired the steam engine and the spinning jenny, the oxygen of England's Industrial Revolution.

In India, almost every metamorphosis has carried within it the embryo of another revolution. Who knew the unification of India would bear the seeds of a secessionist movement in Kashmir? Who knew satellite TV would kick off 24-hour tabloid news channels? Who knew again that a *chutnified* novel

by a gentrified Indian would set off the clatter of a million typewriters? Indeed who knew that a simple word, *satyagraha*, would set off a movement that would consume a once-powerful regime? From the high-yielding varieties of seeds that allowed India to join the world's dining table to the milk revolution that built on the wasteful excess of rich nations, revolutions have blurred boundaries.

India has had countless men and women whose intellectual life has never been impoverished. As V.S. Naipaul, who believes India could do with a lot more thought and action, once said: "Independence had come to India like a kind of revolution. Now there were many revolutions within that revolution." There has been evolution as well, as some revolutions found themselves being absorbed into the mainstream, becoming what they had most loathed. In the following pages,

many such strands of a country still in the making will compete for the reader's attention. There will be the Khalistanis reminiscing about a man named Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale. There will be a Narmada Bachao Andolan activist who has become a beacon for the displaced. There will be a tiny hand-held instrument that has

altered the notion of communication, a car that has made aspirations achievable, television soaps which have set all received wisdom about entertainment on its head, even a form of investment that has convinced ordinary middle Indians that they too can have a shot at the pot of gold. In a country that encapsulates the mass uniformity of the Ford economy as much as it learns the customised choices of the Starbucks universe, in a country that was born of the world's most effective peaceful revolution as much as it has witnessed the most violent bloodbaths, revolutions have powered people.

Time is the school in which we learn, time is the fire in which we burn. The past informs our present and the present shows us the ground shifting beneath our feet. Will the elephant overtake the dragon, will Shanghai be beaten by Mumbai? Even as the world deliberates the future of the nation, India can draw on its rich reserves to continue its argument with itself. Whether it is under-the-radar forces that are reshaping its villages or the klieg-light-clad phenomena that are altering the contours of urban India, India's revolutions today are ensuring its tomorrow.

These revolutions have empowered people, altered perceptions and internalised change